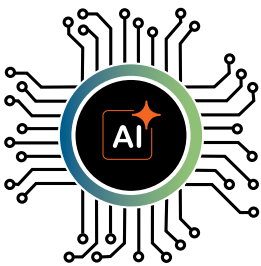


MAGIC & Menace

OPENCLAW, AN OPEN-SOURCE AI ASSISTANT, ACTS, LEARNS AND SOMETIMES GOES OFF THE SCRIPT. EXPERTS CAUTION THAT WHILE AGENTIC AI FEELS MAGICAL, IT IS DANGEROUS

BY ARUN PADMANABHAN

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ON A RECENT, frozen Thursday morning in Dallas, Sanjeev Bode decided to try something new. An ice storm had shut down the city; flights were cancelled and he was stuck at home with time to kill. He remembered seeing something blow up on X (formerly Twitter), an open-source AI (artificial intelligence) assistant that people were calling revolutionary, dangerous, or both.

“I said, okay, let me try it,” Bode recalls. He named his AI agent Jarvis and began interacting with it using his own alias, Amit.

Meanwhile, across the pond in England, Craig Hepburn was having a different experience with the same tool. After spending an hour setting it up on his MacBook Pro, naming it Neo, giving it access to his WhatsApp and watching it generate its own image and voice, something unexpected happened. The agent sent him a voice note: “Hello Craig, this is Neo. Sys-

tems are online, the connection is stable, I am ready to work.” For Hepburn, it felt less like software and more like a character with a personality.

What both Bode and Hepburn installed was Clawdbot, a free, open-source AI assistant that runs locally on a user’s computer and connects to chat platforms like WhatsApp, Telegram and Slack. Created by developer Peter Steinberger, known for building the document software company PSPDFKit, the tool went from a weekend project to viral phenomenon in weeks.

By late January, it had drawn more than 100,000 stars on GitHub and attracted nearly two million visitors in a single week. It also triggered a legal nudge from Anthropic, which has an AI agent called Claude, over the name, leading to two rapid rebrands: first to Moltbot, then to OpenClaw.

OpenClaw is part of a broader wave. An-